长江和黄河

两条大河，一个家

Two Rivers

Two great rivers, one family

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Footnotes mark names and words above HSK 2 (HSK 3.0 lists: github.com/ivankra/hsk30, MIT).

1 今年夏天放假，小川[†]从重庆[‡]坐火车到兰州[§]，来看爷爷。他的表妹小兰[¶]就住在兰州，她天天来爷爷家，跟小川一起玩。爷爷家离黄河[*]很近，走路十分钟就到了。第一天晚上，吃完晚饭，爷爷带两个孩子去河边走走。

谁的河好？

2 小兰站在河边，大声说：“这是黄河！我们兰州就在黄河边上。黄河是中国最好的河！”小川笑了：“最好的河？你看，黄河的水是黄的，一点儿也不好看。我们重庆的长江[#]比黄河大多了。”小兰生气了：“长江是大，可是黄河比长江有名！”“长江是中国最长的河，你知道吗？”小川说。两个人你一句，我一句，谁也不让谁。

† 小川 *Xiǎochuān* Xiaochuan (boy's name)
‡ 重庆 *Chóngqìng* Chongqing (city on the Yangtze)
§ 兰州 *Lánzhōu* Lanzhou (city on the Yellow River)
¶ 小兰 *Xiǎolán* Xiaolan (girl's name)
* 黄河 *Huáng Hé* the Yellow River
长江 *Cháng Jiāng* the Yangtze River

This summer, during the holidays, Xiaochuan took the train from Chongqing to Lanzhou to visit his grandfather. His younger cousin Xiaolan lived in Lanzhou, and she came to Grandpa's house every day to play with him. Grandpa's house was close to the Yellow River, only a ten-minute walk away. On the first evening, after dinner, Grandpa took the two children for a walk by the river. 1

Whose River Is Better?

Xiaolan stood by the river and said loudly, "This is the Yellow River! Our Lanzhou is right on its banks. The Yellow River is the best river in China!" Xiaochuan laughed. "The best river? Look, the water is yellow. It isn't pretty at all. Our Yangtze in Chongqing is much bigger than the Yellow River." Xiaolan got angry. "All right, the Yangtze is big, but the Yellow River is more famous!" "The Yangtze is the longest river in China, did you know that?" said Xiaochuan. The two of them went back and forth, and neither would give in. 2

3 爷爷坐在旁边，一直笑着听。小兰[†]问："爷爷，你说，长江[‡]好还是黄河[§]好？"小川[¶]也说："对，爷爷，你说吧！"爷爷没有马上回答。他说："我们回家吧。我先给你们讲讲这两条河，然后你们再告诉我，哪条河好。"

长江

4 回到家，爷爷拿出家里的中国地图，放在桌子上。他让小川先在地图上找长江。小川很快就找到了："在这儿！长江从西边流到东边，经过重庆[*]，最后在上海[#]流进大海。"爷爷说："对。长江有六千三百多公里，是中国最长的河。"

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‡ 长江 *Cháng Jiāng* the Yangtze River
§ 黄河 *Huáng Hé* the Yellow River
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* 重庆 *Chóngqìng* Chongqing (city on the Yangtze)
上海 *Shànghǎi* Shanghai

Grandpa sat beside them, listening and smiling the whole time. Xiaolan 3
asked, "Grandpa, you tell us: is the Yangtze better, or the Yellow River?" "Yes, Grandpa, you tell us!" said Xiaochuan. Grandpa didn't answer right away. He said, "Let's go home. First I'll tell you about these two rivers, and then you can tell me which one is better."

The Yangtze

Back home, Grandpa took out the family's map of China and laid it on the 4
table. He asked Xiaochuan to find the Yangtze on the map first. Xiaochuan found it quickly. "Here! The Yangtze flows from the west to the east, passes Chongqing, and finally flows into the sea at Shanghai." "That's right," said Grandpa. "The Yangtze is more than six thousand three hundred kilometres long. It is the longest river in China."

5 爷爷又说："长江[1]不但很长，而且水很多，长江的水比黄河[2]多很多。在长江上有很多大船，从重庆[3]可以一直坐船到上海[4]。"小川[5]高兴地说："你看，长江比黄河好吧！"爷爷笑了："别急，还有黄河呢。"

黄河

6 小兰[6]马上在地图上找到了黄河。黄河也是从西边流到东边，经过兰州[7]，最后流进大海。"黄河有多长？"小兰问。"黄河有五千四百多公里，是中国第二长的河。"爷爷说，"它没有长江那么长，可是也很长。"

7 小川问："黄河的水为什么是黄色的？"

1 长江 *Cháng Jiāng* the Yangtze River
2 黄河 *Huáng Hé* the Yellow River
3 重庆 *Chóngqìng* Chongqing (city on the Yangtze)
4 上海 *Shànghǎi* Shanghai
5 小川 *Xiǎochuān* Xiaochuan (boy's name)
6 小兰 *Xiǎolán* Xiaolan (girl's name)
7 兰州 *Lánzhōu* Lanzhou (city on the Yellow River)

Grandpa went on, "The Yangtze is not only long, it also carries a lot of water, much more than the Yellow River. There are many big boats on the Yangtze, and you can go by boat all the way from Chongqing to Shanghai." Xiaochuan said happily, "See? The Yangtze is better than the Yellow River!" Grandpa laughed. "Not so fast. There's still the Yellow River." 5

The Yellow River

Xiaolan found the Yellow River on the map at once. The Yellow River also flows from the west to the east, passes Lanzhou, and finally flows into the sea. "How long is the Yellow River?" asked Xiaolan. "The Yellow River is more than five thousand four hundred kilometres long. It is the second-longest river in China," said Grandpa. "It isn't as long as the Yangtze, but it is very long too." 6

Xiaochuan asked, "Why is the water of the Yellow River yellow?" 7

7 爷爷说：“因为黄河[†]流过黄土高原[‡]，那里的山都是黄色的。河水从那里带走很多黄色的东西，所以黄河的水就变黄了。”

8 爷爷又说：“很早以前，很多中国人就住在黄河边上，在河边吃饭、生活、写字、画画儿。所以中国人说，黄河像妈妈一样。”小兰[§]高兴地说：“你听，黄河跟妈妈一样！”小川[¶]想了想，说：“那长江[*]呢？长江边上也住着很多人。”爷爷说：“对，长江跟黄河一样，也像妈妈。两条河不但给了我们水和鱼，而且给了我们家。”

都到大海

9 小兰问：“那哪条河最好呢？”爷爷没有回答，他在地图上找到了一个地方：青海[#]。

† 黄河 *Huáng Hé* the Yellow River
‡ 黄土高原 *Huángtǔ Gāoyuán* the Loess Plateau
§ 小兰 *Xiǎolán* Xiaolan (girl's name)
¶ 小川 *Xiǎochuān* Xiaochuan (boy's name)
* 长江 *Cháng Jiāng* the Yangtze River
\# 青海 *Qīnghǎi* Qinghai (province)

Grandpa said, "Because the Yellow River flows across the Loess Plateau, where the hills are all yellow. The river carries away a lot of that yellow earth, so its water turns yellow." 7

Grandpa went on, "Long, long ago, many Chinese people already lived along the Yellow River. They ate, lived, wrote and painted by the river. That is why Chinese people say the Yellow River is like a mother." Xiaolan said happily, "Did you hear that? The Yellow River is like a mother!" Xiaochuan thought for a moment and said, "What about the Yangtze? Lots of people live along the Yangtze too." "Right," said Grandpa. "The Yangtze is just like the Yellow River, a mother too. The two rivers gave us not only water and fish, but also our homes." 8

Both Reach the Sea

Xiaolan asked, "So which river is the best?" Grandpa didn't answer. He found a place on the map: Qinghai. 9

9 “你们看，长江[1]和黄河[2]都是从青海[3]流出来的。它们像两个孩子，是从一个家里出来的。”“一条往南走，一条往北走，走了几千公里，最后都到了大海。”

10 爷爷又说：“你们知道吗？我在黄河边上出生，在兰州[4]长大。二十岁的时候，我去了重庆[5]，在长江上开了三十年船。”小川[6]说：“我知道！因为爷爷在重庆工作，所以我爸爸是在重庆出生的。”小兰[7]说：“我妈妈也是在重庆出生的，后来她跟爷爷回了兰州。”

11 爷爷笑着说：“所以，长江是小川的河，黄河是小兰的河，这两条河都是我们家的河。哪条河好？两条都好！”小川和小兰看看地图，又看看爷爷，都笑了。

1 长江 *Cháng Jiāng* the Yangtze River
2 黄河 *Huáng Hé* the Yellow River
3 青海 *Qīnghǎi* Qinghai (province)
4 兰州 *Lánzhōu* Lanzhou (city on the Yellow River)
5 重庆 *Chóngqìng* Chongqing (city on the Yangtze)
6 小川 *Xiǎochuān* Xiaochuan (boy's name)
7 小兰 *Xiǎolán* Xiaolan (girl's name)

"Look, the Yangtze and the Yellow River both flow out of Qinghai. They are like two children who come from the same home." "One goes south, the other goes north. They travel thousands of kilometres, and in the end both reach the sea." 9

Grandpa went on, "Did you know? I was born by the Yellow River and grew up in Lanzhou. When I was twenty, I went to Chongqing, and I drove boats on the Yangtze for thirty years." "I know!" said Xiaochuan. "Because Grandpa worked in Chongqing, my dad was born in Chongqing." Xiaolan said, "My mum was born in Chongqing too. Later she came back to Lanzhou with Grandpa." 10

Grandpa smiled. "So the Yangtze is Xiaochuan's river and the Yellow River is Xiaolan's river, and both of them are our family's rivers. Which one is better? Both are!" Xiaochuan and Xiaolan looked at the map, then at Grandpa, and they both laughed. 11

12 第二天，两个人又一起去了黄河†边上。小川‡说：“明年夏天你来重庆§吧，我带你去看长江¶，坐长江上的大船。”小兰*笑着说：“好啊！可是你别再说长江比黄河好了。”小川也笑了：“好，我不比了。长江跟黄河一样好！”

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The next day, the two of them went down to the Yellow River together again. Xiaochuan said, "Come to Chongqing next summer. I'll take you to see the Yangtze and ride on the big boats." Xiaolan smiled. "OK! But don't say the Yangtze is better than the Yellow River any more." Xiaochuan laughed too. "All right, no more comparing. The Yangtze is just as good as the Yellow River!" 12